Art Appreciation: Forms, Functions and How to Look at a Work

My reviewer for Humanities 1. The goal is to look at any artwork carefully instead of just saying "ang ganda" and walking away.

Art vs craft

Art and craft both need skill, but they lean toward different goals.

- Art is mainly made to express ideas, feelings or a personal vision. Each piece is usually unique, and the artist decides freely what it will look like.
- Craft is mainly made to be useful, and it often follows a traditional pattern or technique that can be repeated. A handwoven banig mat or a clay palayok pot is a good example.

The line is not always sharp. A finely woven textile from a local weaver can be both useful and deeply artistic. So think of art and craft as two ends of a range, not two boxes.

Kinds of art by how we experience them

- Visual arts are seen with the eyes and usually exist as objects in space. Examples: painting, sculpture, photography, architecture, printmaking.
- Performing arts happen live over time and need performers in front of an audience. Examples: dance, theater, music, and folk dances like tinikling.
- Literary arts use written or spoken language as the material. Examples: poems, short stories, novels, plays as scripts, and essays.

Film is often called a combined art because it mixes visuals, performance, sound and storytelling.

Functions of art

Art can do different jobs. A common way to sort them uses three groups:

- Personal function: art lets the artist express emotions, memories or beliefs. A student drawing her lola after she passed away is using art for personal expression.
- Social function: art speaks to or for a group. It can protest, celebrate, teach or unite people. Murals about saving the environment painted on barangay walls serve a social function.
- Physical function: the art piece is used in daily life. Buildings, furniture, jewelry and well-designed jeepney bodies all have physical uses while still being beautiful.

One work can have more than one function at the same time.

Subject, content and form

These three terms come up often in exams, so get them straight.

- Subject: what the artwork shows or is about on the surface. For example, a mother holding a child, a market scene, or a bowl of fruit.
- Content: the deeper meaning or message the artist wants us to get. The mother and child picture might really be about sacrifice or protection.
- Form: how the work is put together. This includes the elements like line, shape, color, texture and space, and how they are arranged.

Simple trick: subject is the "what," content is the "why," and form is the "how."

Representational, abstract and non-objective

These describe how closely a work matches things in the real world.

- Representational art shows subjects we can easily recognize, painted or sculpted close to how they really look. A realistic painting of rice farmers is an example.
- Abstract art starts from something real but simplifies, distorts or exaggerates it. You can still guess the original subject, like a face broken into angular shapes.
- Non-objective art has no recognizable subject at all. It uses only colors, lines and shapes for their own sake, so there is nothing from the real world to identify.

Steps of art criticism

When we judge a work, we follow four steps in order. Do not skip ahead to judging.

- Describe: list what you see without giving opinions. Size, medium, colors, objects, people. Example: "There are three figures in a dark room lit by one candle."
- Analyze: explain how the elements and principles are used. Where is the emphasis? Is there balance? How does the color lead your eye?
- Interpret: say what you think the work means, using the clues you found. What mood or message comes through?
- Judge: decide the value of the work and give reasons. Is it successful? Is it original? Does it achieve what it seems to aim for?

The order matters because a fair judgment should be based on careful looking first, not on first impressions.

Philippine National Artists as examples

The Order of National Artists is the highest honor given by the state to Filipino artists. A few names you can use as examples in essays:

- Fernando Amorsolo, visual arts, known for bright rural scenes, and the first person named National Artist in 1972
- Nick Joaquin, literature
- Lucrecia Kasilag, music
- Lino Brocka, film
- Leandro Locsin, architecture

You do not need to memorize their life stories for this lesson, just connect each name to an art form.

Quick check

- Q: What is the main difference between art and craft? A: Art leans toward expressing ideas and feelings, while craft leans toward useful objects made with repeatable techniques.
- Q: A church built for worship and gatherings mainly shows which function? A: Physical function, though it may also serve a social function.
- Q: What is content in an artwork? A: The deeper meaning or message behind the subject.
- Q: Art with no recognizable subject at all is called what? A: Non-objective art.
- Q: What are the four steps of art criticism in order? A: Describe, analyze, interpret, judge.